

FREE WHITE PAPER

Quotes That Get a Yes

How to present an estimate at the counter or by text, sort repairs into now, soon and later, and handle "that's too expensive."

For independent auto repair shops with ten technicians or fewer.

XSite Auto xsiteauto.com

BEFORE YOU START

Good work deserves a clear yes.

Most declined quotes aren't about price. They're about trust and clarity: a customer who doesn't understand what's wrong, can't tell what's urgent, or feels pushed. Fix those, and more quotes turn into approved work, without any hard selling.

This white paper covers how to understand what the customer cares about, build a quote that doesn't change, sort repairs by urgency, show the problem, present it in person and by text, handle the common objections, and follow up on what was declined. There are scripts throughout. Change the words to sound like you.

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1 OF 10 · BEFORE THE QUOTE

Understand the customer first

The same repair can be an easy yes or a hard no depending on the person. Before you quote, know what matters to them.

WHAT TO DO

1. Ask how long they plan to keep the vehicle. Someone selling next spring wants different advice than someone keeping it ten years.
2. Ask what matters most: cost, safety, getting it back quickly, or avoiding a breakdown on a trip.
3. Ask what they're comfortable approving without a call, and write it down.
4. Listen to the concern in their words. Make sure the quote answers the question they actually asked.

> *"Are you planning to keep this one for a while? That helps me tell you what's worth doing now and what can wait."*

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2 OF 10 · ONE NUMBER

Build the whole quote before you call

Nothing kills trust faster than a quote that changes. Calling with a rough number, then calling back with a higher one, makes the customer wonder what else will change.

WHAT TO DO

1. Price everything before you pick up the phone: parts, labour, shop supplies and tax.
2. Give one total, with the time it will be ready.
3. If there's a real chance of finding more once you're in there, say so up front, with a likely range.

COMMON MISTAKES

- "It'll be around four or five hundred," then an invoice for seven.
- Quoting parts and labour separately and leaving the customer to add it up.

3 OF 10 · PRIORITIZE

Sort it into now, soon and later

A long list of repairs feels like a sales pitch. The same list sorted by urgency feels like advice. Customers say yes more often when they can see you've thought about what really matters.

Now	Safety items and anything that will cause more damage if left: brakes past their limit, leaking brake or fuel lines, steering and suspension parts that are loose.
Soon	Work that's needed in the next few months: brakes getting thin, a slow leak, tires that won't last the winter.
Later	Things to watch: a weeping gasket, worn but serviceable parts, maintenance coming up at the next visit.

WHAT TO DO

1. Lead with the "now" items and price them on their own.
2. Give the "soon" items with prices and a rough timeframe.
3. Mention "later" items briefly, so there are no surprises next time.

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4 OF 10 · PROOF

Show, don't just tell

Customers can't see under their car. A photo, a measurement or the old part turns "trust me" into something they can see for themselves.

WHAT TO DO

1. Take a photo of the problem on your phone: the worn pad, the leak, the cracked belt.
2. Use measurements where you can: "Your front pads are at 2 mm. New is about 10."
3. Keep the old parts for the customer to see at pickup.
4. Explain in plain words what happens if it's left, without exaggerating.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Technical terms the customer doesn't understand.
- Scare tactics. They might win one job and lose the customer.

5 OF 10 · IN PERSON

Presenting at the counter

In person, keep it short and in the same order every time. A clear structure makes you sound confident, and the customer finds it easy to decide.

WHAT TO DO

1. **What we found:** the cause of their concern, in one sentence.
2. **What it means:** why it matters, in plain words.
3. **What we recommend:** the "now" work.
4. **The price and the time:** one total, and when it will be ready.
5. **The question:** ask for a decision, then stop talking.

> *"The grinding noise is your front brakes. The pads are worn through and the rotors are scored, so it's a safety item. Pads and rotors are $480 all in, and we can have it ready by three. Would you like us to go ahead?"*

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6 OF 10 · REMOTE

Presenting by phone and text

Most approvals happen while the customer is at work. The aim is a quick, clear yes or no, with a written record.

WHAT TO DO

1. Call first, using the contact method they chose at check-in.
2. Use the same five-part structure as at the counter.
3. Straight after the call, send the quote by text or email with a photo, so they have it in writing.
4. If you get voicemail, leave a short message and send the written quote right away. Don't just wait.

> *"Hi [name], it's [shop]. We found the cause of the noise: your front brakes are worn through. Pads and rotors are [amount] all in, ready by [time]. Photo attached. Reply YES to go ahead or call me at [phone]."*

In XSite Auto: The board has a "waiting on approval" column, so every car waiting for an answer is visible and nobody forgets to follow up.

7 OF 10 · THE BIG OBJECTION

When they say "that's too expensive"

"That's too expensive" usually means "I wasn't expecting that," not "no." Your job is to help them find a way forward, not to argue.

WHAT TO DO

1. Acknowledge it. Don't rush to discount.
2. Separate the "now" items from the rest. Often the safety work alone is affordable.
3. Offer choices where they're real: a different grade of part, or spreading the work over two visits.
4. Mention payment options if you have them.
5. If they still decline, respect it, write it down, and make sure they know what's urgent.

> *"I understand, it's more than you were expecting. The front brakes are the part I wouldn't put off. That's $480 of the total. The rest can wait until spring if you'd like."*

> *"We can use a different grade of pads that brings it down to $390. They won't last quite as long, but they're safe."*

COMMON MISTAKES

- Cutting the price straight away, which tells them the first number wasn't real.
- Pressure. A customer who feels pushed doesn't come back.

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8 OF 10 · COMMON REPLIES

Other objections

Most objections are really questions. Answer the question behind them, calmly and honestly.

"I'll think about it."	"Of course. Just so you know, the brakes are the urgent part. I'll send you the quote so you have it, and I'll check in on Thursday."
"Another shop quoted less."	"Do you know if that was for pads and rotors, or pads only? I'm happy to look at the quote with you so you're comparing the same thing."
"Do I really need it?"	"Here's the photo. This one is a safety item, so I'd do it now. The others can wait, and I'll tell you when."
"Can you just do the cheapest fix?"	"We can do the minimum to make it safe today. Here's what that is, and what it won't fix."

9 OF 10 · AFTER THE DECISION

Record every answer

Whatever the answer, write it down. It protects you at pickup, and it's where your future work comes from.

WHAT TO DO

1. Record what was approved, the amount, who approved it and when.
2. Record everything declined, with its price and whether it was now, soon or later.
3. Give the customer the list of recommended work in writing at pickup.
4. Set a date to follow up on anything declined.

> **In XSite Auto:** Each job has a notes field for recommended work, such as "Rear brakes at next visit", so it's there the next time the customer comes in.

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10 OF 10 · TWO TO FOUR WEEKS LATER

Follow up on declined work

A "no" today is often a "yes" next month. Customers who declined work are some of your warmest leads, because they already trust your advice.

WHAT TO DO

1. Follow up on "soon" items in two to four weeks, by text or a short call.
2. Bring up declined work again at the next visit.
3. Time follow-ups to the season, such as tires and brakes before winter.
4. Use the declined-work list to fill quiet days.

> *"Hi [name], it's [shop]. When you were in, we noticed your rear brakes were getting thin. We have an opening Thursday morning if you'd like to take care of them before winter."*

TRACK THIS

Quotes approved ÷ quotes given,
and declined work won back, each month.

PRINTABLE

The quote card

Keep this by the counter and the phone.

1. What we found

The cause of their concern, in one sentence.

2. What it means

Why it matters, in plain words. Show a photo or a measurement.

3. What we recommend

The "now" work first. Then "soon" with prices. Mention "later" briefly.

4. Price and time

One total, all in, and when it will be ready.

5. Ask, then stop talking

"Would you like us to go ahead?"

If they say it's too expensive

- Acknowledge it. Don't rush to discount.
- Separate the urgent work from the rest.
- Offer real choices: a different grade of part, or two visits.
- If it's still no, write it down with the price and follow up in two to four weeks.

- [ ] Approval recorded: amount, who and when
- [ ] Declined work written down with prices
- [ ] Follow-up date set

Quotes, approvals and follow-ups in one place

XSite Auto puts every job, repair order and customer in one place, with a board that shows every car waiting on approval, built for shops with ten technicians or fewer.

$99 USD or $139 CAD a month after a free 14-day trial, with no credit card needed and no contract. Done-for-you setup is optional ($495 USD or $695 CAD, one time).

Start a free trial | **Book a 15-minute demo**

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